

**THE BJP CONTINGENT** From left, Champai Soren, Amit Shah and Babulal Marandi during a Parivartan rally in Sahibganj, Sept. 20

**INDIA Strategy**

- **Ride sympathy wave post Soren's arrest in January, portraying BJP as anti-tribal**
- **Build on the women's connect Kalpana Soren cultivated in her husband's absence**
- **Highlight welfare initiatives, particularly Maiyya Samman Yojana, expected to benefit 5.3 million women**
- **Play up perceived injustices by the Centre like denying Jharkhand's rights, including coal royalties**

**NDA Strategy**

- **Leverage PM Modi's image to attract voters**
- **Utilise the tribal roots of four ex-CMs—Babulal Marandi, Arjun Munda, Champai Soren and Madhu Koda—to corner the elusive tribal vote**
- **Push narrative of Bangladeshi infiltrators (read Muslims) taking away Santhal lands and daughters**
- **Promote the 'paanch pran' (five resolutions) to counter Soren's welfare initiatives. These include providing universal basic income to women, cooking fuel, jobs, unemployment allowance and housing**

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**October 19, as Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren** addressed the media in capital Ranchi, he shared a key detail—that his party, the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM), and the Congress will be contesting 70 of the state's 81 assembly seats, and ally Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and the Left parties the remaining 11. But asked about the candidates, the CM responded with a mere "these things can't be disclosed yet".

In contrast, the NDA betrayed no such hesitation in its declaration of seat-sharing or candidates. The BJP will contest 68 seats, the Sudesh Mahto-led All Jharkhand Students Union (AJSU) Party 10, the Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) two, and Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party or LJP (Ram Vilas) one. The BJP has already released its first list of 66 candidates.

Poised to vote in two phases on November 13 and 20, with results to be announced three days later, this will be Jharkhand's fifth assembly election in its 24-year history, a period in which it has seen seven individuals occupy the chief minister's chair on 13 separate occasions, and three bouts of President's rule. Former BJP CM Raghubar Das is the only one to have lasted a full term beginning 2014; the 2005 assembly saw three CMs in five years. No party has been re-elected for a second consecutive term.

That jinx will no doubt weigh heavy on Hemant Soren's mind as he sets out to seek re-election. Despite the alliance winning a majority in the state in 2019, it has been a tumultuous five years in power. Soren has had to move his MLAs to Chhattisgarh twice to prevent alleged poaching attempts. Then, in 2022, alliance partner Congress had to suspend three MLAs after they were found with large sums of cash in West Bengal. Finally, Soren, like the CMs of other non-BJP-ruled states, found central investigative agencies coming after him as well. This saw him spend five months in jail in a case